Triaperformance

TRIAPERFORMANCE GUIDE

Race Execution Guide

How to prepare, run and decide on race day

It covers one thing, and it covers it completely: how to execute a race, and what to do when the plan stops working.

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Contents

Scope of this guide

This is training material. It is not medical or psychological advice.

It covers one thing, and it covers it completely: **how to execute a race, and what to do when the plan stops working.**

It does not cover anxiety or depression, it does not cover loss of motivation as a clinical matter, it does not cover exercise dependence, or your relationship with food or with your body. It also does not treat "mental toughness" as a character trait that needs fixing. Not because those things don't matter — they matter enormously — but because they are not my job. I'm your coach, not your psychologist, and that difference isn't a technicality: it's the line between what I can defend with my experience and what requires a licence.

On nutrition, this guide repeats nothing: everything on fuel, hydration and sodium lives in **The Fuel Kit**, and that's where you should look for it.

Talk to a professional before applying any of this if:

- You have an active injury, or pain a doctor hasn't looked at yet
- You have a diagnosed cardiovascular, respiratory or metabolic condition
- You are pregnant or trying to be
- You take medication regularly
- You are under 18

Talk to a mental health professional if:

This is not a diagnostic checklist. These are observations you can make about yourself, with a threshold of **time or function**, not of mood.

- The low after a race lasts **more than two weeks**, or stops you functioning at work, at home, or with the people around you
- You've lost interest in things that have nothing to do with sport
- Your sleep has come apart and isn't settling
- **You can't take a rest day**, or you train sick or injured because stopping feels impossible
- Your eating or your weight decides whether you train

If thoughts of harming yourself show up, that isn't an appointment you book for next week. Get help today.

What I do and what I don't

I adjust the plan, redistribute load to the sports that don't hurt, and hold the calendar with you. I don't diagnose, I don't assess injury risk, I don't give guidance on medication, and I don't coach weight. When something falls on that side of the line, I refer you out. That's the rule, and it has no exceptions.

> One more, and it organises everything that follows: **slowing down, walking and stopping are decisions with a cost, not failures of character.** This guide will never treat them as giving up.

A note from your coach

You train seriously. You do the intervals, you finish the long runs, you follow the data. You arrive on race day with the engine built.

And then the usual happens: the engine was fine and the race went badly.

For years this got explained with the word *mindset*. The athlete didn't have the head for it, wasn't strong enough, gave up. It's a convenient explanation and it's almost always wrong. What happens in a race isn't a collapse of character. **It's a series of decisions taken in the wrong order, on bad information, that were never once practised.**

The data is fairly clear about where it happens. In an analysis of over two million marathon records, the pacing collapse begins on average at **29.6 km** for men and **29.3 km** for women, and holds for the next ten kilometres. It happens to 28% of men and 17% of women. Not at the start, where everyone is focused. At kilometre 30, once you've already invested everything and the goal starts moving away from you.

That is the part of the race nobody trains you for.

This guide trains it. It won't tell you to be stronger. It gives you the written plan, the three goals, the pace ceiling for the opening kilometres, and — above all — **the procedure for deciding at kilometre 30**: continue, drop a goal, walk, or stop.

One rule organises everything else:

> **Nothing gets decided for the first time at kilometre 30.**

Everything you'll decide when you're empty, you already decided today, sitting down, with a clear head. On race day you don't think. You execute.

Let's get to work.

Iván
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1. The race is decided before the start

There's an asymmetry worth understanding before anything else.

At kilometre 5 you make decisions with a complete brain: glucose available, temperature controlled, no accumulated fatigue. At kilometre 33 you make decisions with your glycogen gone, 2 to 4% dehydrated, core temperature up, and three hours of effort behind you. It is literally a different brain.

And the standard design of an amateur race is exactly backwards: at kilometre 5 there is nothing to decide, and at kilometre 33 everything has to be improvised.

The fix isn't training your head to decide better on an empty tank. That doesn't work. **The fix is to move the decisions forward**, to a moment where you can still think, write them down, and on race day do nothing but read them.

A race plan isn't a prediction. It's a list of decisions already made.

Sections 2 to 6 are exactly that: the decisions you take in advance, in order, and how to rehearse them so that on race day they come out on their own.

2. Your three goals: A, B and C

This is the most important exercise in the guide. If you do only one, do this one.

Most athletes arrive at the start line with **one** goal. A number. And that number has a dangerous property: it's either met or broken. There's nothing in between.

When that number becomes impossible — and in one marathon out of four it does — the athlete is left without an objective at the worst possible moment. There's nothing to hold on to. That's where the race comes apart, and not for lack of legs: for lack of structure.

The correction is simple, and it has to be done before race week, in writing.

Goal A — the perfect day

The time you can run **if everything goes right**. Good weather, no wind, fuelling executed at 100%, no stomach problems, no cramps, two decent nights of sleep behind you.

Goal A is conditional, and it has to be written with its conditions attached. It isn't "3:15". It's: **"3:15, if the temperature is under 18°, if I take all six gels, and if I run the first half at 4:38."**

Once you write the conditions down, goal A stops being a promise and becomes a hypothesis. And a hypothesis can be discarded without the race collapsing on top of you.

Goal B — the normal day

The time you can run **on an ordinary day**. Something goes slightly wrong — something always does — and you still run well.

This is the real goal. It's the one that comes off most often, the one to train for, and the one that should govern your pace in the opening kilometres. The gap between A and B is usually 2 to 4%: on a three-and-a-half-hour marathon, four to eight minutes.

If, writing them down, you find A and B are thirty seconds apart, you don't have two goals. You have one with two names.

Goal C — the bad day

What you do when the day breaks. Extreme heat, a shut stomach, a cramp at 28 km, a pace that never shows up.

Goal C is not defined by a time. It's defined by a condition that depends only on you: *finish it walking and jogging, without injuring myself, and cross the line.* Or, in a race with cut-offs: *make the cut-off.*

Goal C is the most important of the three, because it's the only one still available when the other two are dead. An athlete with a written goal C doesn't have a ruined race. They have a different race.

The fourth line: when today isn't a race day

Under the three goals, write a fourth line. The conditions under which you **don't run**, or don't finish:

> *I don't start if I have a fever or an active infection.*
> *I stop if anything on the list in section 9 shows up.*

This isn't pessimism. It's what a pilot does before take-off: the abort criteria get defined on the ground, not in the air.

How to use them

- **Write them three to four weeks out**, after the simulation race (section 4), once you have real evidence of your pace.
- **Read them on race morning** — all three, out loud if it helps.
- **Drop one step at a time, never two.** A goes to B. B goes to C. An athlete who jumps from A straight to C at kilometre 30 is almost always quitting, not adjusting.

This isn't a mental technique. It's goal planning, exactly like periodising a block: you define the expected outcome, you define the conservative scenario, and you define the floor.

3. The written race plan

A race plan has three parts, and it isn't finished until all three are on paper. This is the same thing I build with every athlete before an A race, and it has the same contents every time.

Pace by segment

Not an average pace. A range per segment, using whichever variable fits your sport and your data: pace, power, or heart rate.

The structure I use, and which is supported by how split times actually behave in long races:

Race	Structure
10k	100–110% of threshold. First kilometre **never** above the range.
Half	First half at the floor of the range. Push from km 14.
Marathon	**First 21k at the floor of the range. Push from km 30.**
70.3 / IM	Run at low intensity, with a hard HR cap per leg. On the bike, forbidden zones on the climbs.

In long-course triathlon there's one extra rule that isn't negotiable: **power spikes on the bike are carbohydrate you're stealing from the marathon.** A climb ridden 40 watts above target doesn't cost you that climb. It costs you kilometre 25 of the run.

Every target pace is conditional. It gets written with its assumptions beside it: fuelling executed at 100%, weather within range, no overcooking the bike. If an assumption falls, the target pace falls with it — and that isn't a failure, that's the plan working.

Fuelling schedule

What, how much, and at which kilometre. Written down. **The Fuel Kit** has the numbers; here all that matters is that they're in your plan and not in your memory.

Two rules that do belong to execution:

- **You eat by the clock, not by hunger.** Hunger arrives late, and by then you're already in deficit.
- **Nothing gets used for the first time on race day.** Not a gel brand, not a drink from the organisers you've never tried, not a salt tab someone handed you at the expo.

The decision playbook (if… then)

This is the part almost nobody writes and the one that most often saves a race.

For every foreseeable problem, a written response in the form **"if X happens, then I do Y."** Not a general principle. A concrete action, for a concrete trigger.

The whole thing lives or dies on the trigger, and that's what separates a playbook that works from a decorative one. A trigger has to be something you can **see or measure**, not something you can feel:

Weak trigger	Useful trigger
"If I feel anxious"	"If my watch shows km 1 faster than 4:35"
"If it's going badly"	"If I pass km 21 more than 90 seconds above my target split"
"If my stomach hurts"	"If I can't get the km 25 gel down"

Examples I use with my athletes:

> *If km 1 comes out above my ceiling, then I slow down at km 2. Not "later on": at km 2.*
> *If I drop a gel, then I take the spare from my belt and bring the next one forward by five minutes.*
> *If I pass km 21 ninety seconds above target, then I drop to goal B and recalculate the pace for the new objective.*
> *If I get a cramp, then I slow thirty seconds per kilometre for two kilometres before deciding anything else.*
> *If my stomach shuts down, then I switch to liquid and salt, and leave the gels until I can swallow again.*

A decent race playbook has between six and ten lines. More than that and you won't remember it; fewer and it doesn't cover the day.

4. The rehearsal

A plan that was never executed isn't a plan. It's an intention.

The simulation race

Four weeks out, at target race pace. Not the full distance: a fraction long enough that the pace stops being a hypothesis.

What you rehearse there isn't only the pace. It's the whole package: the wake-up time, the exact breakfast, the exact kit, the exact gels, the exact warm-up. If something is going to fail, it needs to fail that day and not on the day that counts.

That session produces the evidence you use to write your three goals. If target pace held comfortably, goal A is real. If it fell apart halfway, goal A was a wish and you've just saved yourself finding out at kilometre 30.

The course

Before the race you need to know:

- **Where the climbs are** and which kilometre they land on. A climb at km 8 is a different climb at km 35.
- **Where the aid stations are** and what each one serves.
- **Where the cut-offs are**, if there are any, and the exact time they close.
- **Which direction the wind comes from** on the exposed section.
- **Where your people will be**, if they'll be there.

If the race is in another city and you can cover the last five kilometres on foot or by car, do it. The last five are the ones you'll run with the least capacity to process new information.

Reading the playbook

In the final two weeks, read your decision playbook **three times**. More isn't necessary and less doesn't work.

It isn't memorisation. It's recognition: when the trigger actually shows up, you want something closer to "ah, I've seen this" than "now what do I do?".

5. What you rehearse in each block

Race decisions don't all get practised at the same time. They're spread across the year the same way physical load is, and for the same reason: each thing is learned best in the state the body is already in.

This is how I organise it. It isn't a law of the sport; it's how I work it with my athletes and why.

Base — building the habit of executing what's prescribed

What you practise: finishing the session as it was written.

High volume, low intensity, and one single discipline: the 80-minute easy run lasts 80 minutes, not 74 because the route ended. This looks trivial and it's the foundation of everything else. An athlete who negotiates with the plan in January will negotiate with the plan at kilometre 30.

Also here: the session log (section 11). Start now, not in race week.

Build — rehearsing the effort and the cues

What you practise: holding a number when it burns, and using execution cues.

Intervals are the laboratory. The instruction is simple: **the target of the interval is the prescribed number, start to finish.** No easing off in the last seconds and no accelerating to compensate. A well-executed interval is a flat one.

This is also where you build your execution cues (section 8): one cue for each error you know you have.

Peak and taper — rehearsing the race

What you practise: the whole package.

Simulation race. Plan written and closed. Playbook read. Goals A, B and C written. Course studied.

Off-season — reconnecting and resetting expectations

What you practise: stopping.

Regenerative week, a lot of walking, unstructured training. And two things worth saying out loud:

- **Systemic fatigue lasts about two weeks.** The first tempo after an A race will feel bad. That's normal and it doesn't mean you lost fitness.
- **Fitness is temporary.** You can't hold a peak all year, and trying to is the fastest route to arriving broken at the next season.

It's also the time to go back to the roles you have outside sport — partner, family, friends, work. Not as a recovery technique, but because a long season eats them if you don't deliberately put them back in the calendar.

6. Race week

The taper is the **final two weeks**. The structure I use: a fatigue-reset week about three weeks out, the biggest week at two to three weeks, and an easy race week. The aim is to arrive with the fatigue shed and the minimum stimulus maintained.

And there's one thing I tell every athlete in this week, always in the same words:

> **You're going to feel like you need to train more. Don't.**

The work is done. These two weeks exist to shed fatigue, not to add fitness. The sensation of losing something is the taper working, not failing. Your legs will feel strange — sometimes heavy, sometimes too light — and that doesn't mean anything about Sunday either.

What you do this week:

- Close the written plan and don't touch it again
- Read the decision playbook
- Lay out the kit, the gels and the bib two days in advance
- Sleep well **on Thursday and Friday** — almost nobody sleeps well the night before, and it doesn't matter; the night that counts is two out

What you don't do:

- Don't use anything for the first time
- Don't test a session "just to see where I am"
- Don't change your goals because of a forecast three days out

7. The opening kilometres: the error that decides almost everything

The most common cause of a bad kilometre 33 is at kilometre 3.

This is counterintuitive, which is why it keeps happening. The athlete who blows up at km 33 looks for the explanation at km 33 — *I didn't have the head for it, my legs went* — when the mistake was already made thirty kilometres earlier, back when everything was going well and nobody checked.

Why you go out fast

On the start line you'll have a racing heart, cold hands, one more urge to go to the toilet, and the feeling that your target pace is far too slow.

That is not an emotional problem. **It's a physiological state with one concrete consequence: you're going to run faster than you planned and you won't notice.** High arousal compresses perceived effort. A pace that will feel hard at km 20 feels comfortable at km 2.

Add to that the fact that most races start downhill or on fast flat, that there are thousands of people around you running their own race, and that your glycogen is still full. The conditions are set up for you to go out fast.

There's no mental trick that fixes this. What fixes it is a number.

The ceiling

Write a maximum pace for the first 5 km into your plan. Not a target: a ceiling. A number you don't go above, whatever happens.

The ceiling sits at **the floor of your goal B range**, not goal A. If your marathon range is 4:38–4:45, your ceiling for the first 5 km is 4:45. Slower is fine. Faster is not an option.

And the rule that makes it work:

> **If km 1 comes out above the ceiling, you correct at km 2. Not "later on". At km 2.**

"I'll make it back" is the sentence that precedes most blow-ups. You don't make it back. The seconds you win at km 1 you pay for in minutes after 30, and it's a terrible trade.

If you arrive flat instead of wired

The opposite case exists and gets coached less because it's less dramatic: some mornings you arrive flat, without drive, with the body switched off.

That isn't an attitude problem either. It's solved with the same things as any other morning:

- A full, real warm-up, not a three-minute jog

- The activation routine you already use in training
- Caffeine, if it's part of your protocol — **The Fuel Kit** has the how

And a warning: arriving flat is **not** a reason to go out faster "to see if the body wakes up". That is exactly the same trap from the other side.

8. The middle: where to put your attention

Between the ceiling of the opening kilometres and the decision at km 30 there's a long stretch where not much happens. And that stretch has its own skill: **where you put your head.**

The rule that matters, and the one usually taught badly:

> **What decides where your attention goes is the intensity, not the kilometre.**

You'll read in plenty of places "distract yourself at the start and focus at the end". It's a shortcut, and it fails because a race doesn't change intensity by kilometre — it changes according to what you're asking of the body at that moment.

At low or moderate intensity

Distraction works and **lowers perceived effort**. It's legitimate and it isn't cheating: music, talking to someone running your pace, looking at the scenery, counting things. On a long ride or the bike leg of an Ironman, this is a tool for saving mental energy, and saving mental energy early is part of the plan.

At high intensity

It stops working. Once the effort is high enough, the body's signals occupy your attention whether you like it or not, and fighting that burns energy and returns nothing.

What helps there is directing attention to **something you can do**, not something you can feel. The difference between "this is hard" and "cadence" is that the second one has an action on the other end.

Your execution cues

An execution cue is a word attached to **a specific error you know you have**. Not a motivational phrase: a technical instruction.

What breaks down	Your cue
Your shoulders creep up	*shoulders*
Your cadence drops	*cadence*
You fall backwards in your posture	*chest up*
You clench your fists and jaw	*loose hands*
You check the watch every 200 metres	*eyes up*

Pick **two**. Not five. The two that correspond to the two errors you already know you make, because you've seen them on video or because I've pointed them out.

And they get practised in intervals, not on race day. A cue you use for the first time at km 32 is a word with nothing behind it.

9. Kilometre 30: when the plan fails

The rest of the guide exists so that you can execute this section.

There's a moment in a lot of long races where this happens: the pace is dropping, the goal is moving away, and **you start doing arithmetic about quitting.**

That mental calculation — keep going or not, how far is left, what happens if I stop — is the moment this guide trains. It isn't weakness and it isn't a lack of character: it's what happens when you've invested heavily in a goal that has stopped being reachable. It happens to almost everyone, and it happens in roughly the same place.

What distinguishes an athlete who handles that stretch well isn't enduring more. **It's having a procedure.**

Recognising it

The signal is concrete: **you're calculating instead of running.**

When you catch yourself doing the arithmetic, don't keep doing it on autopilot. That's the point where you enter the procedure.

And the first move is to name the options, because there are three and not two:

1. **Hold the current goal**
2. **Drop one step of goal**
3. **Stop**

Most athletes in crisis only see the first and the third. That's the trap: it turns a race that could have been saved into a binary choice between suffering and quitting. **Option 2 exists, it's the right one nearly every time, and you have to name it out loud for it to show up.**

The three questions

Don't decide by feel. Decide with these three, in this order. They take about twenty seconds.

Question 1 — Is anything on the stop list happening?
Go to the list further down this section. If the answer is yes, there is no question 2. You stop.

Question 2 — Is there something that can be fixed?
Most kilometre-30 crises have a repairable cause, and the repair takes five to ten minutes to take effect:

- **When was your last gel?** If it's been more than thirty minutes, the crisis may simply be hunger. Eat something now and give it ten minutes before you decide anything.
- **When did you last drink?** Same.
- **Are you going faster than you think?** Look at the actual split, not the sensation.
- **Is there a cramp or a mechanical niggle?** Slow thirty seconds per kilometre for two kilometres and re-evaluate.

Don't make a big decision on an empty stomach. It's the most useful rule in this entire section. An enormous number of DNFs are hypoglycaemia misread as a failure of will.

Question 3 — Can I hold this pace to the next aid station?
Not to the finish. To the next aid station. If the answer is no, the pace is wrong and it has to come down — which, most of the time, means dropping a goal.

Dropping a goal

Dropping a goal is not giving up. It's the correct technical decision when the assumptions you built the objective on have changed. Exactly like adjusting the week's plan because you got sick.

How it's done, in order:

1. **You drop one step, not two.** A to B. B to C.
2. **You recalculate the pace** for the new objective. If you're on goal B with 12 km left, what pace do you need? That's your new number, and it's slower — that's the point.
3. **You let the old one go.** You stop looking at the splits for the goal you've just discarded. Continuing to compare against an objective that no longer exists is the fastest way to turn a bad day into a DNF.
4. **You re-segment.** You're no longer running 12 km. You're running to the next aid station. Win that stretch, then the next one.

Segmenting works **after** you've decided which goal you're chasing. Not before: "one kilometre at a time" without having resolved what you're chasing is just postponing the decision.

Walking

Walking isn't failing. Walking is a pacing tool, and most amateur athletes use it too late and use it badly.

What walking costs, with numbers. At 6:00/km, one minute of running gives you about 165 metres. One minute of fast walking gives you about 110. Walking that minute costs you roughly **twenty seconds**. Do the arithmetic at your own pace and you'll see it's almost always less than you fear.

What walking buys: a lower heart rate, a gel you can actually swallow, water that actually goes in rather than over your face, and — this is the important one — the ability to run again afterwards.

The two kinds of walking, and only one of them works:

Walking by decision	Walking by collapse
Chosen, with a limit set beforehand	It just happens, once there's no option left
"I walk the 30 seconds of the aid station"	"I don't know when I'll be able to run again"
You jog again at the point you defined	The walk extends itself
Costs twenty seconds	Costs twenty minutes

How to do it well:

- **Walk the aid stations.** All of them. From the first one, not from km 30. Thirty seconds walking lets you actually drink, and that's the point of the aid station.
- **If you have to walk outside an aid station, set a limit before you start:** to that post, to a count of sixty, to the bend. The limit gets defined **before** the first walking step, not during.
- **Run-walk is a strategy, not a defeat.** From km 32, alternating four minutes of jogging with one of walking is often faster — and considerably less miserable — than the continuous death march a lot of people end up in.

When to stop

This is the only part of the guide with no nuance, and where no goal matters.

Stop immediately and seek medical help if any of these appear:

- **Sharp, localised pain that changes how you land.** Not discomfort: pain that alters your mechanics.
- **Focal bone pain** — a specific point on a bone that hurts when you press it.
- **Chest pain, shortness of breath disproportionate to the effort, or irregular heartbeats.**
- **Confusion, disorientation, not understanding where you are or which kilometre it is.** This is the most dangerous one because it's the hardest to detect in yourself.
- **Dizziness with nausea, cold skin, or you've stopped sweating** in hot conditions.
- **Very dark urine together with severe muscle pain.**

On sodium and hydration problems — including hyponatraemia, which is serious and gets confused with dehydration — **The Fuel Kit** has the full section. I'm not repeating it here because that guide is the one that governs that topic.

Three rules around this list:

1. **No goal justifies ignoring it.** Not A, not C, not finishing. None.
2. **If you stop for anything on this list, you see a doctor.** Not "let's see how I feel tomorrow". That same day.
3. **If you can't assess yourself clearly, that is the answer.** Confusion doesn't self-diagnose. If you're doubting your own ability to judge, you already have the data.

And a general rule that applies to everything medical, in and out of a race: **I don't diagnose.** If any of this shows up, I refer you out and my part ends there. That's not legal caution — it's that it isn't my competence.

The cut-off

If your race has cut-offs, the arithmetic gets done **beforehand**, not while running.

What you need to know before you start:

- Which kilometre each cut-off is at
- The exact time it closes — normally clock time, not time since your own start
- Whether the clock runs from the gun or from when you crossed the mat. **This changes the calculation and a lot of people find out too late.**

The table you carry with you. For each cut-off, the average pace you need from wherever you are. Written down, laminated, or on the back of the bib:

> Cut-off at km 30, closes 14:30 · I started at 9:00 → I have 5:30 for 30 km → **11:00/km average**
> If at km 21 my watch says 3:10, I have 2:20 left for 9 km → **15:33/km**. I can walk it.

That second calculation is the one that saves races, because it turns a panic into a number. Plenty of athletes quit at a cut-off they were going to make comfortably, simply because they never did the sum.

The rule: if the number you need is slower than your fast walk, you carry on. If it's faster than your current pace with no margin, you drop to goal C and accept the cut-off as the day's objective.

10. The closing kilometres

If you got here with a live goal — any of the three — the work in this section is short.

What to do:

- **Segment short.** Aid station to aid station. Post to post if you have to.
- **Use your two execution cues.** This is where technique falls apart and where they actually earn their place.
- **Keep eating and drinking** as far as your plan says. A lot of people stop fuelling at 35 km because "there's not much left". There are twenty-five minutes of maximal effort left.
- **Don't do new arithmetic.** The goal decision is already made. Execute that one.

And something about the finish: if you have anything left, use it. But a finishing sprint only exists if the pace of the preceding kilometres was right. An athlete who finishes with a lot in reserve almost always ran too conservatively, and that's a conversation for the debrief, not for the last 400 metres.

11. Afterwards: the debrief

The race doesn't end when you cross the line. It ends when you've extracted the lesson.

This is the protocol I use with every athlete, and the order matters.

First, the body

Before any analysis: how's the body? Did you eat? Did you sleep? None of what follows makes sense with a dehydrated athlete who hasn't eaten.

Second, your version

Your analysis comes first, before the data. What happened, in your words, before opening any file. If you look at the data first, your memory rearranges itself to fit what it shows, and you lose the most valuable information there is: what you were thinking and what you decided at each moment.

Third, the data

Only then: the splits, the heart rate, the power, compared against the evidence from your training and against the conditions on the day. A worse time in 12 degrees more heat is not a worse time.

Fourth, one lesson

One. Not five. Specific and actionable.

Not "I need to toughen up my head". Instead: *"practise drinking from the aid stations rather than depending on the bottle I carry."* That's a real lesson, it came out of a real race, and it can be trained.

The debrief questions

- What pace had I planned for the first 5 km, and what did I actually run?
- Did I execute the fuelling plan? Where did it break down?
- At which kilometre did the first crisis appear?
- Which of the three goals did I end up chasing, and when did I switch?
- Did I use the decision playbook? Which trigger was missing?
- **What is the one thing I'm going to change for next time?**

And the recovery

Regenerative week. A lot of walking. And the correct expectation: **systemic fatigue lasts about two weeks.** The first tempo will feel bad. That's normal, it isn't a loss of fitness, and it isn't a reason to sign up for another race on impulse.

12. Template — My three goals

Print this one and the three that follow. They're everything you need to carry.

Race: ________________ Date: ________

	Objective	Conditions that have to hold
Goal A		
Goal B		
Goal C	*(no time — defined by finishing)*	

Today isn't a race day if: _______________________________________

I stop if: anything on the list in section 9 appears.

13. Template — My race plan on one page

Ceiling for the first 5 km: __________ *(never faster than this)*

Pace by segment

Segment	Pace / power / HR	Course notes

Fuel

Km	What	How much

Cut-offs

Km	Closes at	Average pace needed

14. Template — My decision playbook

Between six and ten lines. The trigger has to be something you can see or measure.

IF this happens (something I see or measure)	THEN I do this (one concrete action)

15. Template — Post-race debrief

Race: ________________ **Result:** ________

1. The body: did I eat, did I sleep, how am I? _______________________

2. My version, before looking at the data:

____

____

3. The data, against the conditions on the day:

	Planned	Actual
First 5 km		
First half		
Second half		
Gels taken		

4. At which km did the first crisis appear, and what did I decide? ______________

5. Which trigger was my playbook missing? ______________

6. The one thing I change for next time:

____

16. To close

None of this will make you stronger. That was never the idea.

What it does is take you out of the position of having to invent — on an empty tank, three hours into an effort — decisions that could have been made calmly, at home, with a pen and paper.

The athlete who reaches kilometre 30 with three written goals, a respected pace ceiling and eight lines of playbook isn't running a better race. **They're running the same race with far fewer decisions outstanding**, and that's most of what separates good execution from bad.

Want to build your plan together? If you'd like your next race plan — pace by segment, fuel and decision playbook — built from your data and your history, that's part of 1-to-1 coaching.

Email: coach@triaperformance.com
WhatsApp: +57 310 543 7088

Let's get to work.

Iván
Founder & Head Coach, Triaperformance

Sources

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